

The Institutional Stance (Jara-Ettinger & Dunham, 2024)

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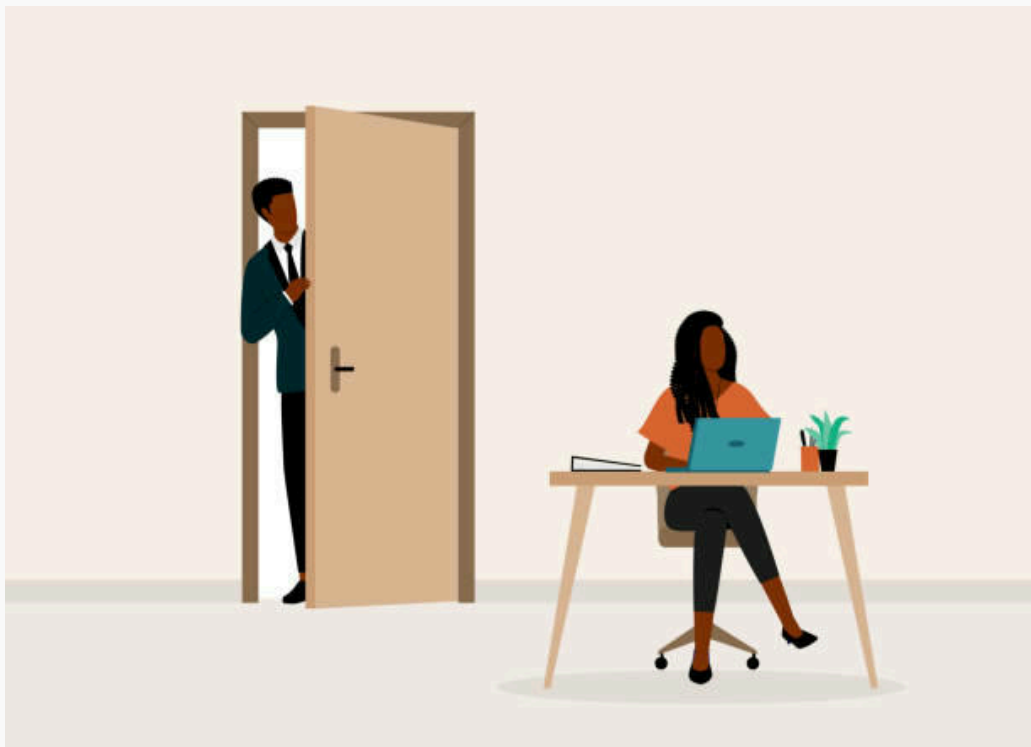
Outline

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3. Three Stages of Institutions
4. Institutions as Graphs
5. Creating New Institutions
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Introduction



The Puzzle: Friday at the Office



Imagine you're interning at a company.

Your boss comes in and asks you:
“Can you help me get lunch and print out these documents?”

You get it done.

The Puzzle: Saturday at the Movies



You go to watch a movie.

Then your boss spots you from a few rows ahead and asks you to get popcorn for them.

Would you do this?

The Mentalistic Stance Prediction

At the office:

Boss desires: lunch, documents

Boss believes: intern will get it if asked

Intern desires: to help boss

Intern believes: they can fulfill this task

At the movies:

Boss desires: popcorn

Boss believes: intern will get it if asked

Intern desires: to help boss

Intern believes: they can fulfill this task

Theory of Mind says: Movies scenario should be unsurprising

- Same mental states, same belief-desire structure

But it feels WRONG. Why?

The Institutional Stance Explanation

At the office:

Boss occupies role: “CEO”

Intern occupies role: “assistant”

Role-based norms: CEO can delegate tasks, assistant complies

Humans automatically track which roles are operative in each context

At the movies:

Boss: person at a movie theater

Intern: person on a date

CEO/assistant roles are NOT ACTIVE in this context

Behavior violates norms

The Rental Car Example

Laurie arrives at a rental car agency. Paul greets her and helps with the paperwork.

Fee is higher than expected → argument starts.

Paul briefly excuses himself. A few minutes later, Alex appears and picks up the discussion with Laurie **right where Paul left off**.

Mentalistic stance: Transfer of Paul's beliefs/desires to Alex is strikingly odd!

Institutional stance: Unsurprising. Same role = same goals/behaviors.

Compare to Personal Relationships

Imagine during a personal argument with a close friend, the friend excuses themselves and a casual acquaintance steps in to continue arguing...

Now it would be bizarre!

The institutional stance is **not** warranted in personal relationships—transfer of goals would be surprising, if not off-putting.

Intuitive Theories and Norm Violations

What is an Intuitive Theory?

Intuitive theories are cognitive frameworks humans use to explain and predict behavior Like scientific theories, they:

- Make predictions about unobserved phenomena
- Explain causal relationships
- Support counterfactual reasoning

Unlike scientific theories:

- Often implicit and automatic
- Develop early in childhood
- May not be consciously accessible

Examples: intuitive physics, intuitive psychology (Theory of Mind), intuitive biology

Understanding Norm Violations

Theory of Mind (Mentalistic Stance):

Norms are **inferred** from mental states “They violated a norm because they failed to consider my beliefs/desires” Norm violations = failures of mind-reading

Theory of Institutions (Institutional Stance):

Norms are **first-class citizens** “They violated a norm because they acted outside their role” Norm violations = violations of institutional structure

The institutional stance treats social norms as fundamental features of reality, not derived from individual psychology

Four Lines of Evidence for Theory of Mind

1. Evidence from infants

- Infants as young as 6 months track others' beliefs and knowledge states
- False belief understanding emerges early (implicit by 15 months)
- Gaze-following and joint attention by 9-12 months
- Suggests ToM is foundational to human cognition

2. Function in society

- Enables coordination without explicit communication
- Predicting others' actions based on their mental states
- Understanding deception, teaching, and cooperation
- Essential for human social complexity

Four Lines of Evidence for Theory of Mind (cont.)

3. Neural circuitry

- Dedicated brain regions: temporoparietal junction (TPJ), medial prefrontal cortex (mPFC)
- Consistent activation across mentalizing tasks
- Disruption leads to difficulties in social cognition
- Suggests specialized cognitive architecture

4. Automatic behavior

- Spontaneous mentalizing occurs without conscious effort
- Hard to “turn off” mental state attribution
- Adults automatically track others’ perspectives even when irrelevant
- Suggests ToM is a default mode of social cognition

Conclusion: Theory of Mind is well-established as a core human cognitive capacity

Three Stages of Institutions

The Puzzle of Animal Social Coordination

Theory of Mind is powerful but cannot explain all social complexity

Many species exhibit complex social coordination and cooperation

Yet these species lack the sophisticated mentalizing abilities of humans

The Question: If animals don't have Theory of Mind, how do they coordinate and cooperate with one another?

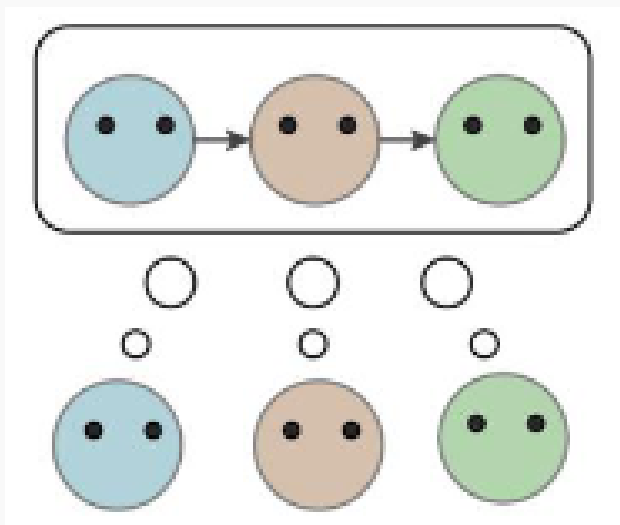
A Hypothesis: Three Critical Stages

Solutions to social coordination evolved through three critical stages:

1. **Proto-institutional:** Rigid role-based systems (biologically determined)
2. **Fixed institutional:** Role-filler independence (roles can be swapped)
3. **Generative institutional:** Grammar of institutions (uniquely human)

Each stage adds flexibility and representational power

Stage 1: Proto-Institutional



The core idea: Learn that specific individuals occupy specific roles This allows us to:

- Predict how this individual will act
- Understand how to interact with them
- Different roles = different social affordances

Example (kinship): From young age, learn to identify who mother is and distinguish her from other humans

Stage 1: Key Limitation

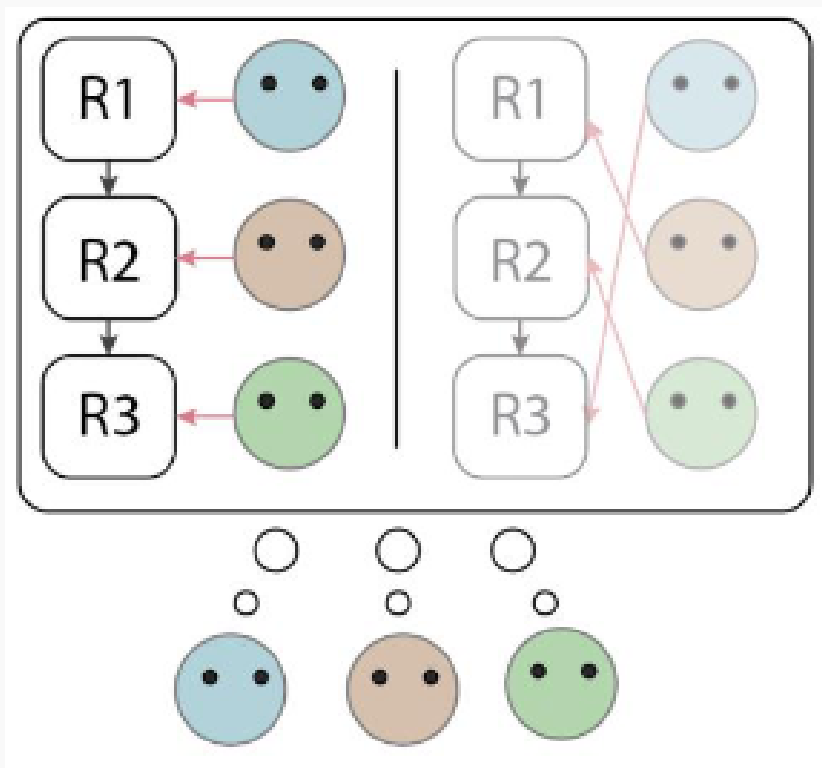
No abstract representation of role vs. occupier

The agent IS the role—just an association of specific individuals to social affordances

No role swapping possible

Still enables coordination without mentalizing

Stage 2: Fixed Institutional



The core idea: Any individual can occupy specific roles

Abstract representation of roles independent of who occupies them

Agents can track and remember:

- Which role an individual occupies
- When roles change
- How to adjust behavior accordingly

Stage 2: Examples

Baboon dominance hierarchies: Dynamic, continuously renegotiated

- Know that Alex is **currently** alpha (not inherently alpha)
- Specialized intelligence for tracking role changes

Lions coordinated hunting: Two center hunters, two wings

- Role specialization + ability to switch
- Must understand all roles need filling

Stage 2: Key Limitation

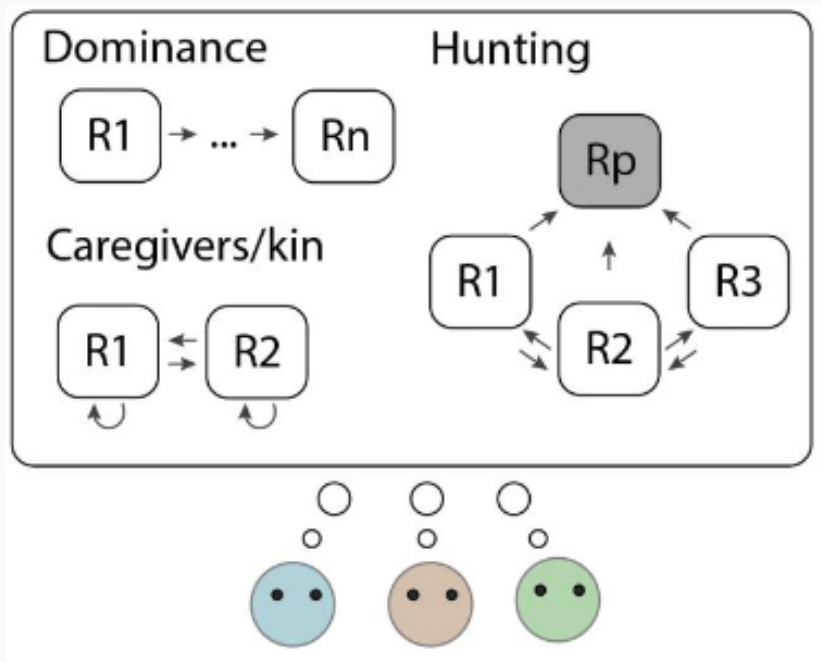
The set of roles available to interpret behavior are pre-determined

No cultural evolution or emergence of novel institutional structures

Cannot create new roles or institutional arrangements

The institutional representations are fixed—determined by biology or evolutionary history

Stage 3: Generative Institutional



The core idea: Generative system to synthesize novel institutional structures

Multiple institutional representations operating simultaneously:

- Dominance hierarchies
- Caregiving/kinship relations
- Hunting coordination

Must reason about how these structures combine and interact compositionally

Stage 3: The Grammar of Institutions

Humans have an intuitive **Theory of Institutions** (akin to Theory of Mind)

This enables us to:

1. Identify normatively structured systems of interconnected roles
2. Compositionally construct new such systems
3. Determine which agents occupy those roles
4. Use that knowledge to interact with others

The explosion of institutional diversity:

Reading clubs, sports teams, university committees, governments, startups, homeowner associations...

Institutions as Graphs

What is an Institution?

An institution is a graph of roles with normative relations

Nodes = Roles

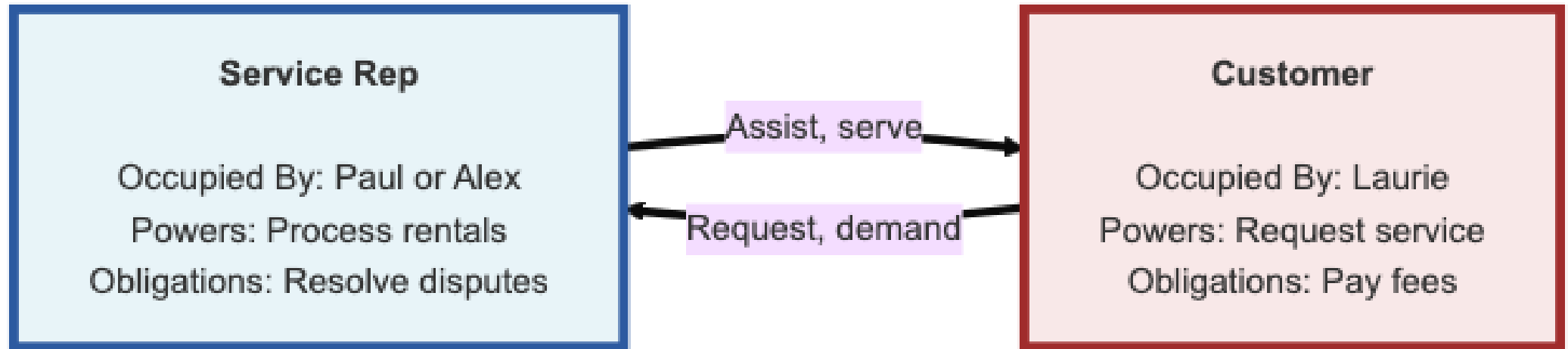
- Who can occupy the role
- Powers granted by the role
- Obligations imposed by it

Edges = Relations between roles

- How roles interact with one another
- Can be directional or undirectional
- Can grant social power over another role

Key insight: Roles are not isolated—they're understood as part of a broader institutional structure

Example: Rental Car Agency



Role-Filler Independence: Paul and Alex can both occupy the Service Rep role. When Alex replaces Paul, Alex inherits all norms of the role.

The Institutional Stance as an Intuitive Theory

To take an institutional stance is to use knowledge of graph structure as a **causal model** to interpret behavior

Like Theory of Mind, it supports prediction, interpretation, and explanation

But **how do we know** the institutional stance is a proper intuitive theory?

Answer: It satisfies the four **Gopnik-Meltzoff structural features** of intuitive theories

Four Structural Features of Intuitive Theories

1. **Abstract:** Representations used to interpret behavior (roles, norms) differ from observable data (actions)
2. **Coherent:** Theoretical constructs work together as a single system—multiple components needed to interpret behavior
3. **Causal:** Roles have causal and explanatory power in the counterfactual sense
“The behavior would not have occurred had the agent not been occupying this role”
4. **Ontological commitments:** We use the system to make counterfactual claims and predictions

Why Graph Structure Matters

Not just a collection of isolated norms

The rental car example revisited:

- Paul and Alex occupy the same **node** (service rep)
- This node has relations to the **customer** node
- When Alex replaces Paul, he inherits these relational norms

Contrast with personal relationships:

- Friend arguing with you: not part of formal institutional graph
- No “friend $\rightarrow$ friend” edge norm for argument-continuation
- Substitution violates expectations

Creating New Institutions

The Generative Capacity of Humans

We can explicitly represent institutional structures and reason **about** them

Not just reasoning **through** them (like proto-institutional animals)

This enables two uniquely human capacities:

1. Taking an institutional stance as an analytic tool

Reveal hidden role-based systems

2. Social constitution

Create genuinely new domains of behavior and social reality

Analytic Tool: Revealing Hidden Structures

We can analyze phenomena we might not initially think of as institutional

Example: Race, gender, and caste systems

Often essentialized (thought of as deep quasi-biological kinds)

But can be analyzed in **structural terms**

Revealed as hierarchical systems of interlocking social roles

“Woman” as a structural position defined in subordination to “man”

Once revealed → we can evaluate, modify, or intentionally subvert them

Social Constitution: Creating New Realities

Some entities are **socially constituted** (not just constructed)

Their existence is actively sustained by institutional structures

Examples: Ballots, voting, citizenship

Socially Constituted vs. Socially Constructed

Socially Constructed:

Hammers, carpentry, carpenters

Social forces involved in creation, but existence doesn't require social agreement

A hammer remains a hammer even if institutions change

Socially Constituted:

Ballots, voting, citizens

Existence requires institutional structures

A ballot can cease to be a ballot through institutional change

Even without changing physical properties

Conclusion

Implications: The Power to Create and Transform

The institutional stance enables us to:

1. Analyze existing institutions

Reveal hidden hierarchies and role-based systems

2. Critique unfair systems

Evaluate oppressive institutional structures

3. Imagine alternatives

Consider how to modify or erase unjust institutions

4. Create new realities

Synthesize novel institutional structures that genuinely create new social kinds The generative aspect allows us to imagine and pursue genuine institutional alternatives

Questions & Discussion